

CONCORD WITH COMPOUND SUBJECTS AND RELATED USES OF PRONOUNS

by

E. J. REVELL

Toronto

Introduction

1. This study is based on the relatively homogeneous corpus of narrative formed by the books of Judges, Samuel, and Kings. The study of compound subjects in this corpus is restricted to those representing human beings, and to those of which one component is singular. Where a compound (as defined here) acts as subject of a verbal clause, the verb may precede or follow the compound subject; it may be singular or plural in either position.¹ It is argued here that the position of the verb, and its number, is deliberately chosen in accordance with the function of the clause, and of its subject, in the narrative context. That is, this article is based on the view that concord in Biblical Hebrew is not simply a means of marking grammatical relationship. Where variation is possible, it is used in a manner similar to the use of the pronouns "tu" and "vous" in French. The variations, contrasting with the simple grammatical basis of concord, are used to add expressive content to the narrative.

2. The use of pronouns in this way can only be understood in relation to its context. The use of "vous" typically signals deference, but it may be used, where "tu" is expected, to convey estrangement. Scholars are understandably wary of appeals to the context to justify an interpretation of a passage. The term "subjective", which inevitably applies to the use of context as a guide to meaning, may seem enough to condemn the suggestion. The context is, however, often the only source of essential information.

¹ Where a compound subject contains only plural nouns, its verb is plural. Where it contains only collectives, or collectives and plurals, the verb may be singular or plural whether it precedes or follows its subject (as in Judg. vi 3; 1 Sam. xiv 15, xviii 16; 2 Sam. iii 37; 1 Kgs v 5; 2 Kgs xxv 26).

4. The choice of number in the verb is usually seen as governed by its position relative to the compound subject.³ However, this factor does not govern concord in other cases in which choice of number (as with collective subjects) or choice of person (as in deferential speech) is available. Grammars point out that a verb preceding a feminine or plural subject may be masculine singular in form, but it seems unlikely that this phenomenon has any relevance for compound subjects as defined here.⁴ Levi suggests that a verb with a following compound subject is likely to be plural where an object or adverbial precedes it, or stands between it and its subject, but these features can have little significance. In Judges ix, where closely similar clauses differ in separating the verb from the following subject, singular verbs are used in both (ix 32, 34, quoted in §10). In 1 Sam. xxviii 1, the verb is both preceded and followed by an adverbial, but there, too, it is singular.⁵ There is, then, no strong reason to believe that the choice of number in a verb is determined by its position relative to a compound subject.

The structure of compound subjects

5. Five different types of compound subject can be recognized:
A. A conjunction joins one or more nouns or nominal phrases to the initial component (a noun or pronoun, typically singular, but see §15). There is no other indication that they are related, as in

1 Sam. xxvi 7 *dwd wʔbyšy* David and Abishai.

³ Exceptions are, however, admitted where the verb follows the subject, as in J. Levi, *Die Inkongruenz im biblischen Hebräisch* (Wiesbaden, 1987), p. 52 (5), cf. GK §146 *e*.

⁴ A range of examples is listed in GK §145 *o, r*; A. B. Davidson *Hebrew Syntax* (Edinburgh, 3rd edn, 1901) §113(b); C. Brockelmann *Hebräische Syntax* (Neukirchen, 1956) 50a. Such subjects are usually non-human. The majority are feminine singular, and there is no reason to separate these from other cases in which masculine singular forms have feminine singular antecedents, as in 1 Sam. ii 20, xxx 2.

⁵ Levi ([n. 3] p. 50) here follows M. Moreshet, "The Predicate Preceding a Compound in the Biblical Language", *Leshonenu* 31 (1967), p. 256. A singular verb is separated from a following compound subject in the corpus in 21 of 80 cases (26%), a plural verb in 5 of 10 (50%). If the figures are limited to constituents which do not usually stand between verb and subject (ignoring pronominal suffixes, the particle *nʔ*, prepositions with pronominal suffix, and the adverb *šm*) the figures are 11 of 80 cases (14%) for singular and 2 of 10 (20%) for plural. There is even less support in the corpus for the view that an item preceding the verb is a conditioning factor.

individual. This usually represents the conventions of the society reflected, as in "Saul and the people" (1 Sam. xv 9), "David and Abishai" (1 Sam. xxvi 7), also "Her brother-in-law and her husband" (1 Sam. iv 19, 21) which does not represent the viewpoint of the wife, but follows the convention represented by "Hophni and Phineas" (1 Sam. i 3, etc.). Occasionally, a person of lower status is named before one of higher because of his significance in the narrative context, as in "Jonathan and Saul" (1 Sam. xiv 41) where the placing of son before father reminds the reader that Jonathan, whose technical guilt is already known, is the reason that the pair have been picked.⁷ Presumably, it is possible that two individuals should be absolutely equal in status and in relevance to the context, but some circumlocution would be needed to show this; the implications of word order for significance are so strong that a compound of type A does not.⁸ In this article, then, it is considered that all compounds treated are of the "principal and adjunct" type. The various types of subject listed are, then, differentiated by the extent to which the status of the initial component as "principal" is made evident.

Number in a verb preceding a compound subject: plural

7. A verb preceding a compound subject is usually singular (107 of 117 cases, 92%). It is significant that, in eight of the ten cases in which the verb is plural, the subject is of type A; the remaining two (1 Sam. xxxi 7; 2 Sam. ii 32) are of type B. In most cases where a preceding verb is plural, then, the structure of the subject does not emphasize the status of the initial component as principal. The use of a plural verb ignores this status; it shows all components of

⁷ The order "Saul and Jonathan" occurs some ten times. Compare "Manasseh and Ephraim" (Gen. xlvi 1), following the usual convention by placing the firstborn first, with "Ephraim and Manasseh" the usual order, showing the status resulting from the blessing of Jacob recorded later in that chapter. In such cases, knowledge of the context shows that the "marked" (non-standard) form is being used to convey particular information, as when "tu" is deliberately used where "vous" is expected.

⁸ A comparable situation occurs with the use of the *waw* consecutive imperfect in narrative clauses. It typically represents an action temporally sequential to that in the preceding clause. However, in 1 Kgs xviii 30 a verb of this sort moves the action to a point before the "time of the *minhah*" mentioned in the preceding verse (cf. v. 36). Some other structure would have to be used if the narrator wished to show in verse 30 that he has abandoned temporal sequence.

Is used towards the end of an incident in a longer narrative section. Gideon is here thematic actor. The following clauses record his pursuit and capture of these two Midianites, so there is no reason to use a singular verb to mark one of them as principal actor.⁹

Number in a verb preceding a compound subject: singular

9. A singular verb is typically used before a compound subject in narrative contexts in which the singular component of the compound, the "principal" is the main focus of the narrator's attention, as in

1 Sam. xxvi 7 *wyb³ dw³ w³byšy ʔl h³m lyh*

David and Abishai came (s) to the people at night

The singular verb emphasizes the fact that David is principal actor. It is probably true to say that, in a narrative clause of this sort, the use of the singular is "unmarked"; a singular verb is used unless the information provided by the plural is required. Even so, the use of the singular can still carry the meaning suggested. The use of *vous* in addressing someone superior in age or status does not lose its connotations of deference because it is "unmarked" in the situation. A plural verb could be used before a compound subject; the use of the singular represents a choice. This choice emphasizes the fact that the initial component of the compound is principal actor, a fact already shown by the structure of the compound.¹⁰ The particular significance of such emphasis is shown by the context. It is often continued by the use, in following clauses, of singular subject pronouns, co-referent with the compound (see below §22). A singular verb may precede a compound subject in similar situations in subordinate clauses, as in 1 Sam. xiv 14 (quoted in §7); 1 Kgs xi 16; 2 Kgs xvi 5.

⁹ A singular verb is, however, used in Judg. viii 21 *wy³mr zbh wšlmn^c* "Zebah and Zalmunna said (s)" where the action (speech) is significant for the course of the narrative.

¹⁰ It might be argued that this is shown to be incorrect by the plural pronoun in "Zebah and Zalmunna said (singular) '... hit us ...'" (Judg. viii 21). However, the use of number in first and second person pronouns is independent of the number of the introductory designation of speaker or addressee, as will be shown in another article. Here, the plural implies group solidarity, as (also after a singular verb) in 1 Sam. xxi 6; 2 Sam. xv 14, xx 6; 1 Kgs xii 9. The singular would imply the personal concern of the individual, as (after a plural verb) in Judg. xii 5; 1 Sam. v 10.

ponent of the compound as principal actor, just as where the verb precedes the subject. Thus in

2 Sam. xx 10 *wywb wbyšy hyw rdp hry šb bn bkry*

Joab and Abishai his brother pursued (s) Sheba ben Bikri.

Joab is the focus of the narrator's attention. David rejected Joab, preferring Amasa (2 Sam. xix 14, xx 4) and then Abishai (2 Sam. xx 6) in his place. 2 Sam. xx 10 shows how Joab rids himself of Amasa, and regains his old position, with Abishai as his subordinate. Consequently, this final clause, shows him acting as principal.¹³ A singular verb following a compound subject is used in a similar way (to recognize the addressee, who is represented by the first component of the subject, as principal) in 2 Kgs iv 7, as described in §21 below. A similar example occurs outside the corpus in Esther iv 16 "I and my girls will fast in the same way", where the first person singular verb recognizes the status of the speaker, Esther, as principal actor, as instigator and director of the action. Compare the use of the plural in Esther vii 4 "We have been sold, I and my people..." where the plural verb ignores the speaker's position as principal indicated by the structure of the compound subject. Esther is here showing solidarity with her people.

12. Where the verb following a compound subject is plural, ignoring the status of the singular component as principal, the clause is often terminal, in that the following clause introduces a different topic, in which neither the principal of the compound nor the adjunct is involved, as in

1 Sam. xxiv 22 *wylk šwl ʔl bytw wdwd wšyw ʕlw ʕl hmswdh*

Saul went to his house, and David and his men went up (p) to the "fortress".

Here the contrast between the two subjects is marked by the initial position of the second. Antithetical pairs of this sort are often used

¹³ As far as I know, where principal and adjunct differ in person or gender, a singular verb following a compound subject (as defined here) always agrees with the principal, not with the nearest component of the compound, as shown in Exod. xxi 4; 2 Kgs iv 7; Esther iv 16; Neh. v 14. This is consistent with the view of the significance of the structure of the compound, and of the choice of number in the verb, presented here. The idea that such usage is erroneous, and so must be removed by emendation (as 2 Kgs iv 7, see §21) or explanation (so Levi [n. 3], p. 52 (4) and n. 24) reflects an unrealistic view of the relationship between the "rules" describing the common usage of a language and the usage acceptable in that language.

14. A singular participle occasionally heads a predicate following a compound subject, as

1 Sam. xviii 16 *wkl ysrʔl wyhwdh ʔhb ʔt dwl*
All Israel and Judah loved (s) David

Both components of the subject are collective, so interpretation is beyond the scope of this article.¹⁵ A singular participle follows the first component of a subject of type D in

1 Kgs xx 16 *wbn hdd šth škw bskwt hwʔ whmlkym...*
Ben Hadad was getting drunk in the tents, he and the kings...

Ben Hadad, the leader of a huge invading army, is one of the two major participants in the events described. The use of the singular participle draws attention to his actions as principal. Another case is to be seen in

Judg. xviii 17 *whkhn nšb pth hšʕr wšš mʔwt hʔys...*
The priest was standing in the gateway, and the 600 men...

The failure to represent “the priest” by a pronoun following the participle, and the fact that the “600 men” are not related to “the priest” by a pronoun, may be seen as reasons for rejecting this example. However, neither phenomenon is without parallel, and other possible analyses of the syntax appear at least equally unlikely.¹⁶ Whether the definition of “compound nominal” is narrowed to exclude this case, or expanded to include it, the intention is clearly to present the priest and the 600 men as performing the same action in the same place, so the subject is semantically compound. The form of the type D subject emphasizes the status of “the priest”, who is thematic actor in this chapter, as principal, and this status is confirmed by the use of a singular participle. As might be expected, then, the evidence suggests that the choice of number in a participle heading a predicate with a compound subject is determined in the same way as it is in verbs.

¹⁵ The singular could be held to agree with *kl* “all”, but a single collective (as *yšrʔl* or *hʕm*) is more commonly treated as plural where preceded by *kl* than where used alone.

¹⁶ For the omission of the pronoun see Gen. xix 30a (where the versions do not treat *wšny bnwyw ʕmw* as a separate clause), also 1 Sam. xxix 10 (discussed in n. 11). For the lack of pronoun linking the second component of a structure of this sort with the first, see 1 Sam. xxx 10; 2 Kgs ix 14. No doubt further examples of both could be found.

but this is an isolated comment, so there is no way of supporting the suggestion.

Examples of contrasting usage

17. The above arguments on the significance of the choice of number in a verb with a compound subject can be further supported by a comparison of structures presenting the same or similar information in different contexts. Statements on the death of Saul and the anointing of Solomon provide an opportunity of this. These examples can also serve as illustrations of the significance of the relative position of subject and verb. A group of clauses used to give instructions is added as further illustration of this aspect of the matter.

18. The death of Saul and his associates is referred to in four clauses.

1 Sam. xxxi 6 *wymt š'wl wšlšt bnyw...*

Saul and his three sons died (s)...

1 Sam. xxxi 7 *mtw š'wl wbnw*

(They saw that) Saul and his sons were dead (p).

2 Sam. i 4 *wgm š'wl wyhwntn bnw mtw*

Also, Saul and Jonathan his son died (p).

2 Sam. i 5 *mt š'wl wyhwntn bnw*

(How do you know that) Saul and Jonathan his son died (s).

1 Sam. xxxi 6 summarizes the events recorded in verses 2-4. The singular verb confirms the status of Saul as principal actor in those verses, and marks his death as the most significant in terms of the narrative. The object clause in 1 Sam. xxxi 7 gives the people's perception of the event, Philistine victory, and the death of all likely leaders of Israel. The verb is plural; in terms of this speech there is no purpose in recognizing Saul as principal. In both clauses the verb precedes the subject; the event is the main concern. In 2 Sam. i 4, a messenger reports to David on the defeat to Israel, using a form of end focus (see n. 17) to add the information that Saul and Jonathan have died. The preposed subject draws attention to the new topic. The plural verb again shows that both participate equally in the event. In 2 Sam. i 5, David questions the messenger about their death. The question concerns the event: did they die? The verb consequently precedes the subject. The verb is singular,

compound subject in the other examples (see §10), but their relevance for 2 Kgs iv 7 is supported by examples with first person principal in Esther iv 16; Neh. v 14, and by the demonstration above that choice of number in a verb is independent of its position relative to the subject.¹⁸ It could be suggested that the use of the singular in 2 Kgs iv 7 is inconsistent with the relationship seen in §12 between the use of the plural and terminal position. However, usage of the sort studied here has limited resources. It is not possible to express both intimacy and deference through a pronoun of address in French. Either “tu” or “vous”, indicating one or the other, must be used (e.g. to a parent) according to habit and the exigencies of the particular situation. The use of the singular in 2 Kgs iv 7 is similarly the result of choice; a plural verb can be used in address to an individual, as in 1 Sam. xxii 13; 2 Sam. xi 20, xvii 21; 1 Kgs iii 26; 2 Kgs iii 15. There is, then, no reason not to interpret the Hebrew text in a manner consistent with the usage of that text. It is unreasonable to maintain that consistency in form ought to be shown in Hebrew in the same way as in familiar classical or modern languages of Europe, which belong to a different family.¹⁹

Pronouns co-referent with a preceding compound

22. A pronoun co-referent with the compound subject of a preceding clause is generally plural, but may be singular, representing the principal.²⁰ A singular pronoun may represent the principal alone, as in

¹⁸ The use of the plural in the LXX is irrelevant unless it can be shown that it was not used in conformity with standard Greek usage, nor with a *Vorlage* which had shifted to the use of plural, in conformity with the usage more common overall in Hebrew in a verb following a compound subject.

¹⁹ This is shown by Arabic usage, both classical, see W. Wright *A Grammar of the Arabic Language* (3rd edn, Cambridge, 1896-8) II, §§ 141-7), and modern standard, see *The M.E.C.A.S. Grammar of Modern Literary Arabic* (compiled by the Middle East Centre for Arab Studies, Beirut, 1965, p. 8). Some features in which Arabic concord differs from standard European recall that of Hebrew, possibly reflecting common origin. E.g. the occasional treatment of names of population groups as feminine, as in Judg. iii 30; 1 Sam. xxvii 8; 2 Sam. viii 2,5,6, x 11, xxiv 9; also Arad letter 24.20. Cf. Wright, §147.

²⁰ Levi (n. 3), p. 53. His estimate of the use of the singular (p. 52, n. 26) is too low, as is shown by the number of examples referred to below. Where a compound does not act as subject, a following co-referent is also usually plural (about 80%), as in 1 Sam. ix 22, xii 8, xv 9, xvi 5. Here also, a singular may be used to represent the principal, as in Judg. iv 7, ix 16; 2 Kgs i 9,11. A pronoun co-referent with a preceding implied compound (type E of §5) is usually singular (as in 2 Sam. x 17, xii 29), but may be plural (as in 1 Sam. xxviii 4; 2 Kgs iii 26).

an action can provide an explanation of the MT in some cases where emendation is often resorted to, as

Judg. xvi 19 *wtqr' l'ys' wglh' ʔt šb' mhl'pwt r'sw*

She (Delilah) called for a man and had him shave the seven locks...

(Literally "she shaved...")

Cf. *wthbs* "she saddled" (2 Kgs iv 24), where emendation is not felt necessary, although it is unlikely that the subject, a "great woman" (2 Kgs iv 8) who had a servant handy, and did not fetch the animal (iv 22), herself prepared it for riding. Similarly, it seems reasonable to suggest that *wyrmsnh* in 2 Kgs ix 33 (literally "He trampled her") should be translated "He had them (the horses) trample her".²¹ Cf. *wysr'pm* "He burned them" (2 Kgs xxiii 4), where emendation is not suggested, although it is unlikely that the king personally burned the objects he had had others remove from the temple. Versional support for emendation in such cases is likely to reflect what was customary in the language of the version, just as (I imagine) advocacy of emendation reflects (to some extent) what is customary in modern languages. I.e. English customarily uses the subject pronoun to represent the authority, not the actor, where the action is building, but not where it is cutting hair.

25. Singular co-referents of a compound subject may be used to show the principal of the compound as authority for action in alternation with plural, indicating action as a group, as in

1 Sam. xxviii 8 *wylk hw' wšny' ʔnšym' mw' wyb'w... wy'mr...*

He went, and two men with him, and they came to the woman at night, and he said...

The singular verb "he said" shows Saul as authority (or possible as sole actor) where significant action is undertaken. The plural verb "they came" shows the group in action where Saul's part is not distinctive.

2 Kgs xxv 1 *b' nbkdn'sr mlk bbl hw' wkl hylw' ʔl yrwšlm wyhn' ʔyh' wybnw dyq...*

²¹ The use of the "N form" 3rd person feminine singular suffix here does present a problem in the Hebrew. See *HUCA* 60 (1989), p. 15 (a). If the *nun* were not present, the form could be taken as a defectively written plural, but the shift from plural (easily intelligible) to the singular of MT (regarded as unacceptable by those who emend) would be difficult to explain.

provided to support any such suggestion. The range of meaning with which the Hebrew pronouns are used clearly cannot be adequately expressed simply by their basic categorization in terms of person, number, and gender. One common departure from such categorization is seen in the strong tendency of the language to concentrate on the principal actor wherever a group is shown acting together with its leader. The same logic governs the choice of number in the verb in cases of this sort both where the subject is represented by a formal nominal compound, and where it is not.